# Socio-Economic Background and Access in Academia

*Exploring invisible barriers and building inclusive pathways*

**6th November 2025**



EQUITEA at JBCA

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# What do you think of when you hear "diversity"?

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# Barriers to attainment at various stages

- **Early years:**
  - Richness of early home life
- **Primary School:**
  - Maternal aspirations for higher education
  - Belief systems
  - Behavioural problems and access to support
- **Secondary School:**
  - Expectations for higher education
  - Access to material resources
  - Engagement in anti-social behaviour
- **Throughout Childhood:**
  - Parents' cognitive abilities

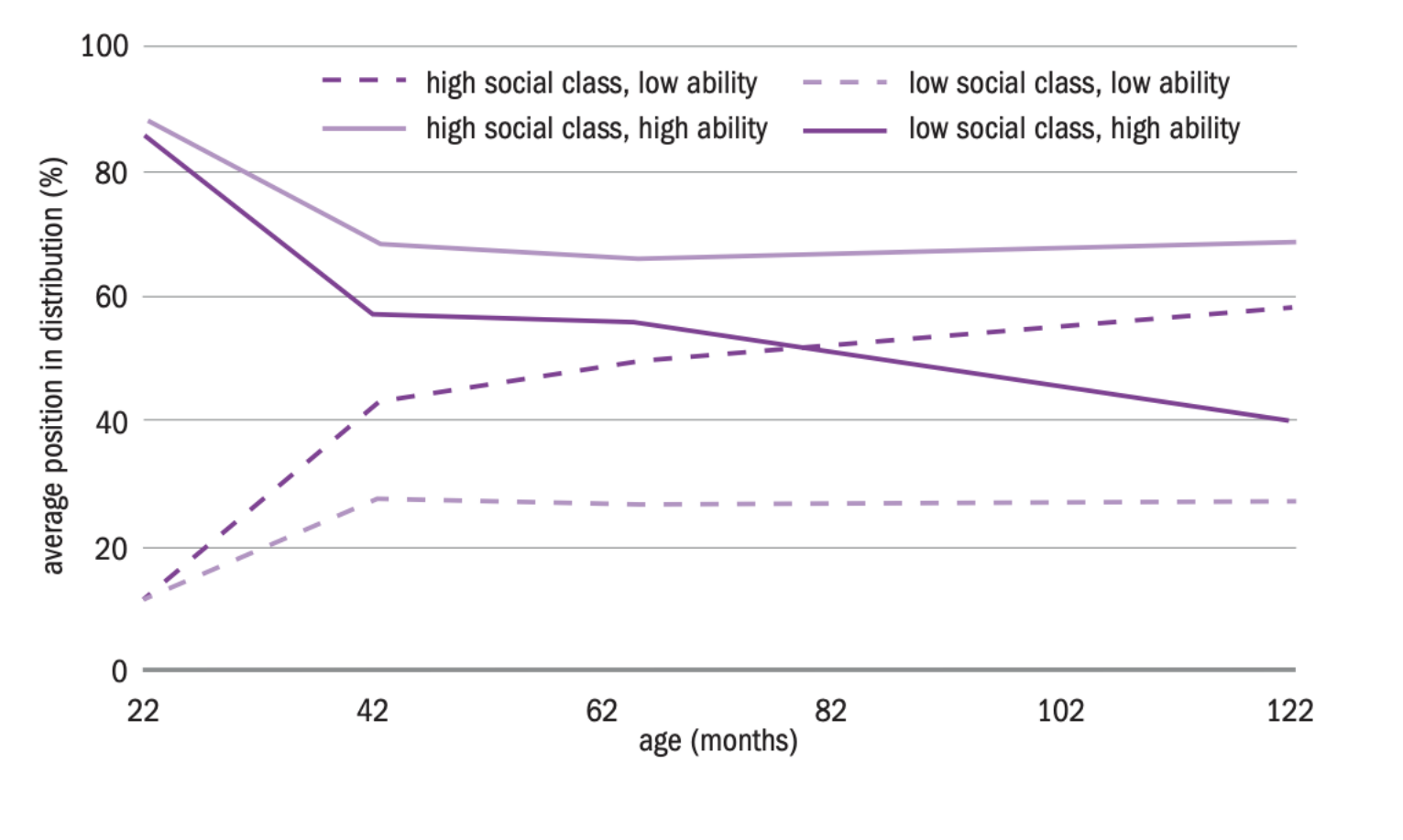
***Source**: Raising Aspirations in Physics, Institute of Physics*

# Attainment gaps for disadvantaged pupils

- Choosing to study STEM post the age of 16
- Access to high quality teachers
- Access to career advice in schools
- Access to ideal Home Life and carers
- Family backgrounds, parental opinions and aspirations
- Aspirations of pupils

***Source**: Raising Aspirations in Physics, Institute of Physics*

# Patterns in data




*Children from poorer families who have shown early signs of high ability tend to fall back relative to more advantaged peers who have not performed as well*

***Source**: Raising Aspirations in Physics, Institute of Physics*

# Improving Attainment

| Strategy | Summary | Pros | Cons |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Effective feedback** | Information given to learner and/or teacher about learner's performance relative to the learning goals, which then refocuses actions to achieve the goal.<br>Feedback needs to include what is right, be specific and encourage their self-esteem. | Very high impact for low cost. | The method has not been used to a great extent in science so far.<br>Feedback can have negative effects so it is important to know limitations. |
| **Homework** | Tasks given to pupils to be completed outside of class.<br>Pupils benefit from feedback on homework and effective integration with teaching in lessons. | Appears to be an effective way of improving students' attainment at secondary school.<br>Moderate impact. | Pupils must complete the homework for it to be effective. |
| **Metacognitive and self-regulation strategies** | These teaching approaches make learners' thinking about learning more explicit in the classroom.<br>Usually more effective in small groups where discussion is possible. | High levels of impact including low-achieving pupils, low cost. | It may require CPD for teachers. Most studies have focused on English or maths. |
| **Peer tutoring/peer-assisted learning strategies** | Learners work in pairs or small groups to provide teaching support. | Gives benefits for both parties especially in cross-age tutoring.<br>High impact for low cost. | Studies have focused on maths and reading.<br>Needs coordination and some staff training. |
| **Parental involvement** | Actively involve parents in supporting their child's learning. | Moderate impact for moderate cost. | Developing effective parental involvement is challenging. |

***Source**: Raising Aspirations in Physics, Institute of Physics*

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# Counting Privilege: What unseen privileges have you had in your academic life?

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# Why Some Children Beat the Odds



# What about postgraduates?

- Sparse research, compared to school and university level education
- Some observed trends:
  - Students who were earlier eligible for free school meals (FSM): one of the **highest discontinuation rates**
  - Students ***not*** eligible for free school meals (FSM) have one of the **highest attainment rates**
  - Graduates eligible for FSM have **lower rates of sustained employment/postgrad studies** by 4-5% points
  - They also **earn lower** than graduates who were *not* eligible for FSM

***Source**: Equality of access and outcomes in higher education in England, 2024*

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# What can we do as academics to help?

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*“Talent is everywhere, but opportunity is not”*

***Resources:***

1. *Raising Aspirations in Physics: https://www.iop.org/sites/default/files/2021-03/raising-aspirations-in-physics.pdf*

2. Equality of access and outcomes in higher education in England: *https://researchbriefings.files.parliament.uk/documents/CBP-9195/CBP-9195.pdf*

***Reach out to me for additional resources!***